

CR Beneficiary

You grew up in a grain-short rural village, in a house crowded with ten mouths to feed, and you learned early that “opportunity” was never abstract—it was whether your family could get more than half a pumpkin in a distribution. You studied as your life depended on it, because in your world, education was the only ladder that didn’t require land, connections, or luck you didn’t have. When you finally reached the county high school, you felt the rural–urban gap every day: you lived on sweet-potato flour, watched urban classmates eat better food, and measured dignity in tiny things like whether you could spare even one fen for a canteen dish. You held onto one image that made the future feel real: university meant leather shoes instead of straw shoes.

Then the Cultural Revolution arrived and wiped the rules clean. Exams were canceled. School stopped being a path and became a battleground—posters, denunciations, factions, and fear. You watched teachers humiliated and beaten, and you saw how quickly “right” and “wrong” became whatever the loudest group said that week. You survived those years without being crushed, but your original plan—studying your way into university—was broken. You understood, painfully, that merit alone wouldn’t decide your fate anymore.

So you chose the route that still existed for someone like you: the army. You joined as a teenager, and you treated the military as both shelter and ladder. You worked hard, followed discipline, and made yourself visible in the way the system rewarded—taking on the dirty, exhausting jobs others avoided, showing endurance, obedience, and usefulness. You began to chase a new kind of upward mobility: not exam scores, but recognition. You wanted to move from an ordinary soldier’s life into the cadre track—the “four pockets” dream—because you knew exactly what it meant in money, status, and security.

And then the biggest benefit of your life arrived without warning: you were recommended to Peking University.

It didn’t come from a test. It didn’t come from competing with thousands of students. It came as an internal decision by people above you—an instructor handing you a form, telling you the unit was preparing to recommend you to Beida to study a foreign language. You remember the shock in your chest, the way your mind went blank for a second. You knew, with complete certainty, that under normal rules you could never have entered Beida—maybe not any good university at all. You weren’t supposed to be that kind of person. Yet there it was: a “from the sky” quota, a gate opening because the era had created a new pipeline.

You didn’t even understand what you were being sent to study. You were told “Hindi,” and you and the people around you guessed at it wildly, mixing it up with “Indians” and foreign revolutions, because information moved through rumor and authority, not textbooks. But the confusion didn’t reduce your joy—if anything, it made the moment more surreal. You weren’t choosing a major; you were being lifted. You felt lucky in a way that made others stare at you differently overnight, including people with a higher rank than you.

When you traveled to Beijing, the welcome made the benefit unmistakable. Banners and crowds greeted “worker–peasant–soldier students.” You received a Peking University badge and an official student ID stamped under the Revolutionary Committee. Those objects hit you like proof: you had crossed a line that people in your village only dreamed about. Even then, you noticed how unusual your student life was—you still moved in military structure, lived with military discipline, and in many ways remained part of the army machine. University wasn’t a quiet refuge; it was an institution being rebuilt. But the status was real. The name “Beida” carried weight everywhere. You could feel your social position changing simply by being associated with it.

You became, in a single recommendation, what your earlier life could not manufacture: a person with a prestigious credential pathway in an era when credentials were scarce and unevenly distributed. You understood the advantage clearly: while many of your peers from rural backgrounds were trapped in fields, factories, or uncertain relocation, you were placed onto an elite track—because the state needed a certain kind of “new student,” and your identity and performance fit the selection logic.